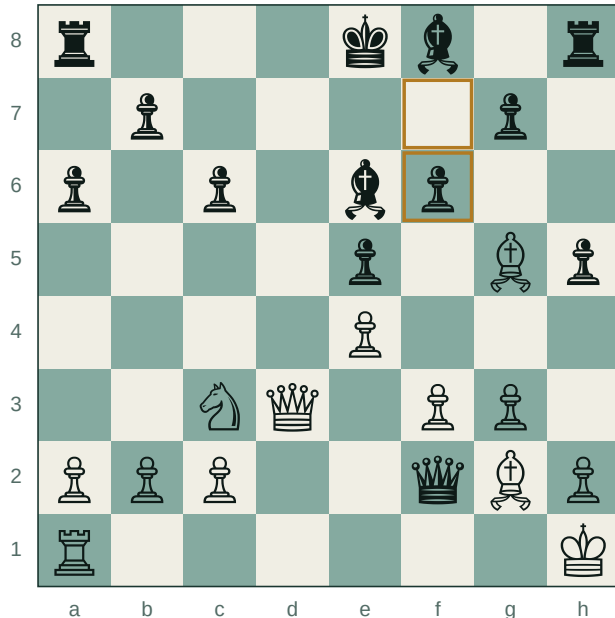


Trapping a piece: White, move 17

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 16...f6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17. Be3 Bc4 18. Bxf2 Bxd3 19. cxd3

17.Be3 The bishop moves from g5 to e3. Recorded reply: **17...Bc4**.

18.Bxf2 The bishop captures the queen on f2. Recorded reply: **18...Bxd3**.

19.cxd3 The pawn captures the bishop on d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -2 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.